

AUGUST 2019

Independence month for us Indians is always special, because we like living free, and also getting stuff for free. Cue the independence day sale advertisements!



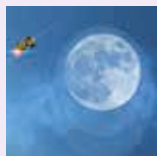
SMARTPHONE MARKET GROWS

A market research report said that the Indian smartphone market grew by an impressive five percent in Q2 of 2019. We Indians love our preferred brands, because six out of seven phones sold in India belong to one of the top five smartphone brands – Xiaomi, Samsung, Vivo, Oppo and Realme. Samsung also closed the gap on Xiaomi with their skew of budget offerings. BBK group, the parent company of Vivo, OnePlus, Realme and Oppo accounts for 30 per cent of all smartphones that are sold in India. In contrast, the feature phone market in India saw a sharp fall from previous quarters and years, thanks to lowered demand for Jio phones.

EAVESDROPPING

It was revealed in August that Microsoft was listening in to users' private Skype calls, and its excuse for doing so was

to improve its voice-enabled services. Even at the time this was not really surprising, because researchers had proved that Amazon, Apple and Google were also all doing the same thing. It was a no-brainer really, when you realise that these four companies all have an AI assistant that users can talk to, and thus, obviously, have to listen and record in order to be able to answer user queries. Now, how they use the recordings is what really matters, but we're not really privy to that information unless there is misuse and a whistleblower steps forward.



CHANDRAYAAN-2

August was the month when Chandrayaan-2 entered the orbit around the moon after having travelled for about a month after it took off from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota. It was preparing for a September landing of the Vikram Lander...



ASTEROIDS AND MUSK

Elon has a way of starting controversies even when he doesn't mean to (or so we think). Thus, an innocent tweet exchange between him and MMA commentator, comedian, and podcaster Joe Rogan made the world lose its sh**! In the tweet Musk said a big asteroid would eventually come, and we had no way of protecting/defending ourselves from it. While the world panicked, NASA rushed in to save the day by assuring people that no big asteroids were headed to earth in the next 100 years at least, and that governments and space agencies were studying many different ways to deflect a rogue asteroid if one ever comes...

Also

- Apple announced that India's first Apple store would be opened in Mumbai
- Apple sued Corellium for virtualising iOS on ARM

SEPTEMBER 2019

The weather gets hotter and the technology news does too!



HIDE THE LIKES

Both Facebook and Instagram announced their plans to hide like counts, which was a positive step forward, given that they really serve no purpose except feed our egos, our biases and try and get us to put up fronts, or engage in certain behaviours to get likes. Kind of like how we train dogs to sit up and beg, by giving them little treats and pats on the head...



VIKRAM CRASH

Look, technically, the Vikram lander was successful. ISRO said it would land on the moon, and it did. So what if it landed a little harder than anticipated and technically "crashed". Since the main mission was always the orbiter, and the Vikram lander was a bonus, at least we got the Indian flag on the moon

again, after Chandrayaan-1's probe carried a flag. Onwards ISRO! Time for some Indians to go to the moon...



AIR INDIA VS MACBOOK

Air India issued an advisory to passengers to not try to carry 15-inch MacBooks on flights, as there were concerns for about batteries. This applied to 15-inch MacBooks which were purchased anytime between September 2015 and February 2017. The advisory was due to a recall issued by Apple for the devices to test for overheating batteries.



IPHONE BUG

Google researchers at Project Zero announced a bug that they were researching and were trying to fix along with Apple. The

flaw in iOS allowed certain websites to hack iPhones and get access to all the contacts, all of a user's photos, give real time access of location, and stealing files from the file system. It even gave them access to all the texts and emails on messaging apps such as WhatsApp, Gmail and more. *shudder*

Also

- Joker malware on the Google Play Store infects 24 apps and about half a million users
- Amazon Alexa announced that it would be able to understand and respond in Hindi
- OnePlus CEO announced that the OnePlus TVs would be manufactured in India
- iPhone 11 Pro Max, 11 Pro and 11 go on sale all across India
- OnePlus 7T spotted on Geekbench and fanboys go wild!